"THOUSANDS OF WHITE PARACHUTES DROPPED THROUGH AN INFERNO OF FLAK, WHILE ... GLIDERS RAMMED HIGH-TENSION CABLES IN SHOWERS OF BLUE SPARKS."

FRENCH PILOT PIERRE CLOSTERMANN DESCRIBES AIRBORNE LANDINGS ON THE RHINE, MARCH 1945

The men also had to exhibit unquestioning instant obedience to their superiors. Fortunately officers were generally of high quality and won the respect of their men, as did NCOs promoted from the ranks of the parachute volunteers.

The airborne troops were trained to be dropped behind enemy lines, where they would have to be capable of fighting unsupported in small units. They had to learn to operate radios, carry out sabotage with high-explosives, fight at night, and survive for long periods without resupply. Having to carry with them all the equipment needed for light infantry operations, they were so encumbered that it was hard for them to board their C-47 transport aircraft, let alone jump out of them in the air. This was especially true of men attached to machine-guns or mortars.

Service diary
A lightweight service diary was part of a soldier's basic kit.

POSTED OVERSEAS

North Africa was the destination for the first US airborne troops sent overseas. On the night of 9 July 1943, units of 82nd Airborne made their first combat jump as part of the invasion of Sicily. The 82nd also participated in the invasion of mainland Italy at Salerno the following September. Most American airborne troops, however, were sent to Britain to prepare for the Normandy landings. These young men not only had no previous experience of war, but the vast majority had never been outside the US. Carried across the Atlantic on overcrowded troop ships, they arrived at bases in rural England, an environment radically different from any they had known. Released from the constraints of their homes, they were hell-raisers when off the leash. But in camp rigorous training continued to occupy all their energies.

In the Sicily landings, strong winds, the inherent problems of night flying, and enemy anti-aircraft fire had resulted in paratroopers landing scattered over a wide area. Despite this, a similar nighttime jump, with accompanying glider landings, was planned to accompany the invasion of Normandy in June 1944. Large-scale exercises in Britain in the run-up to D-Day did nothing to suggest that problems had been overcome, but 82nd and 101st Airborne were



Operation Market Garden
US paratroopers jump from troop transport planes to land in a Dutch field during Operation Market Garden, 1944. Allied glider troops have already assembled in the foreground.